

RELIC SHEET — THE KEYSTONE COIN (THE BOUDICA BINDING)

DESIGNATION	The Keystone Coin (a.k.a. The Boudica Coin, "The Anomalous Piece" — Birmingham Museum catalogue reference: Unrecovered Item #7)
TIER	2 — Threatening (+2 Corruption when the coin is used in the re-burial ritual)
FORM	A gold coin, approximately 2.1 cm diameter, Anglo-Saxon in style but with anomalous iconography: a woman's face on the obverse that does not match any known die. The features are... wrong. The mouth is slightly open. The eyes appear to follow the viewer. The reverse shows a heptagonal pattern — seven points, no known Anglo-Saxon parallel. The coin is warm to the touch at all times. Temperature: 37°C — human body temperature — regardless of ambient conditions.
ARTIFACT DIE	d6 — Strained . The coin has held a binding for 1,900+ years. It was never meant to be permanent. The Anglo-Saxon reinforcement in the 7th century bought time, not eternity. The die is low because the binding has been weakening incrementally for centuries — the coin's removal accelerated a process already underway.
RISK TAG	Volatile — The binding is fragile. Removal of the coin from the earth accelerates entity awakening. Re-burial is time-sensitive. The entity actively resists re-binding — the ritual is contested. The coin's Artifact Die steps down if the re-burial ritual fails.
CORRUPTION EMISSION	Aura — +1 Corruption at scene start for anyone in the binding locus zone (the farm epicenter). The blight leaks ambient Corruption proportional to the entity's proximity to waking. The coin itself is inert above ground — it emits no Corruption when not at the locus.

ORIGIN

In 78 CE, the Roman governor Gnaeus Julius Agricola authorized an exceptional expense: gold, measured by weight, to be buried at a site in the province of Britannia. The purpose — recorded in a ledger now held in the Vatican Apostolic Archive — was "a binding." The entity bound was not named. The ledger is an accounting document, not a theological treatise. The Romans were precise about payments, not about what they were paying for.

The binding held for 500 years. By the 7th century, the original Roman gold was corroding — gold does not rust, but the earth around it was changing. An Anglo-Saxon king of Mercia (Penda or his successor — Eadwine's chronicle is ambiguous) reinforced the pact by burying additional gold at the site. This gold

became known in the 20th century as the Staffordshire Hoard. A monk named Eadwine recorded the reinforcement in his chronicle, now held in the British Library. The coin designated the "keystone" was placed at the binding's center point, 1.2 meters below ground. It remained there until 1987.

In 1984, archaeologists excavated most of the Staffordshire Hoard. They missed the keystone coin — it was deeper than their ground-penetrating radar reached. In 1987, farmer Arthur Dunn's plough struck it at 1.2 meters. He pocketed it. He told people at the pub. He left for a fishing trip. He hasn't returned. The binding has been leaking ever since.

ACTIVATION

Activation Condition (Passive — Not Standard)

The coin does not "activate" in the traditional sense. Its effect is passive and location-dependent. When buried in the earth at the binding locus (a specific point on what is now Arthur Dunn's farm in Staffordshire), the coin sustains a pact that keeps the bound entity dormant. When removed from the earth, the binding weakens. The coin itself is inert above ground — it is merely gold. The power is in the pact, not the object. The coin is a key. The lock is the earth. The door is the binding.

Mechanical Effect

Binding Sustenance (Passive): When buried at the binding locus, the coin maintains a supernatural pact between the Roman Empire (and its successors in interest) and an unnamed pre-Celtic entity. As long as gold remains in the earth at the locus, the entity is dormant. The effect is binary: gold present = binding holds; gold absent = binding weakens. There is no partial binding. There is no gradual effect. The coin is either in the earth or it is not.

Re-Burial Ritual: To restore the binding, a coin from the original hoard (any gold from the Roman or Anglo-Saxon deposits will work — the pact specifies "gold, measured by weight" without specifying a quantity) must be buried at the binding locus while the binding words are spoken. The words are recorded in Eadwine's chronicle (Old English) and in the Roman ledger (Latin). Either version works. The ritual takes approximately 10 minutes. Upon completion, the

binding is restored immediately. The blight recedes. The entity returns to dormancy.

Corruption Cost: The agent performing the burial ritual pays +2 **Corruption**. The entity resists re-binding — the agent bears the psychic cost of standing at the threshold and closing the door. This is not a negotiation. The entity does not consent. The agent forces the door closed, and the entity pushes back.

Limitations: The coin does nothing above ground. It cannot be "activated" for any other purpose. It is not a weapon, a tool, or a source of power. It is a key that works in exactly one lock. The binding is not permanent — gold does not corrode, but the earth shifts. The pact will need reinforcement again, centuries from now. The Anglo-Saxons understood this. The Covenant should too.

Artifact Die Roll

Roll the Artifact Die (d6) after the re-burial ritual, whether successful or not:

- **1:** Die steps down (d6 → d4). The coin is nearly spent. One more attempt is all it has.
- **2+:** No change.

FRACTURE CONDITION

Tier 2 — Scene Scale: The coin's Artifact Die reaches d4 and rolls a 1 — not during handling, but during the re-burial ritual. The entity resists. The binding words are spoken, the coin is placed in the earth — and the ground rejects it. The coin flies upward, glowing hot, and lands several meters away.

For the next 60 seconds, the entity is *partially present* — visible as a heat-shimmer in the air, a sound like fabric tearing, a voice that speaks in a language that predates human speech. It is not Boudica. It is not Celtic. It is older. Everyone at the locus takes +3 **Corruption**. The experience is not combat — the entity cannot be fought. It is a glimpse of something that was never meant to be seen.

The coin can be retrieved and the ritual attempted again, but the Artifact Die has reset to d4 — the coin is nearly spent. One more attempt is all it has. If the second attempt also fails (another 1 on d4), the coin shatters — not physically,

but metaphysically. The gold remains, but the pact is broken permanently. The entity is unbound. The Decay track advances by 2.

CONTAINMENT PROFILE

Quiescence Condition: The coin is inert above ground. Standard storage — a lead-lined box, a vault drawer — is sufficient. The danger is not the coin. The danger is the absence of the coin from the earth at the binding locus.

Long-Term Monitoring: The binding site must be monitored. The Covenant should establish a long-term observation post at the locus. The gold will remain intact, but the binding is not eternal. In approximately 300-500 years, the binding will need reinforcement again — additional gold buried at the site, the binding words spoken. The Anglo-Saxons understood this cycle. The Covenant should file a standing order.

Inadvertent Activation Risk: None. The coin cannot be activated. Its only property is sustaining the binding when buried at the locus. Handling the coin above ground carries no Corruption risk and no supernatural effect. The coin is warm (37°C), which is unsettling but harmless.

CONTAINMENT TRUTHS

Three facts must be discovered before the binding can be restored:

CT-1 — Trigger Condition: The coin must be removed from the earth at the binding locus. The binding weakens proportionally to how long the locus remains empty. The coin above ground is inert. The danger is the empty hole. *Sources: L1 (Dunn's Farm — soil analysis of the hole), L6 (Dr. Rhys's dig records — coordinates of the anomalous coin match the locus), L5 (Roman ledger — specifies "gold in earth"), NPC4 (Father Matteo — confirms the ledger's meaning).*

CT-2 — Appetite: The entity — the "Red Woman," Boudica's curse as adopted by something older — is drawn to anger, resentment, and the sense of having been wronged. It feeds on the emotion of wanting back what was taken. Areas with high social tension experience stronger blight effects. The entity does not hate. It *wants*. Its wanting is toxic to living things. *Sources: L4 (Eadwine's chronicle —*

describes "a wanting that wears the shape of anger"), L1 (the blight pattern — worse near the pub where people argue), NPC1 (Mrs. Albright's dreams of a woman in red).

CT-3 — Quiescence Condition: The binding is restored when gold from the hoard is re-buried at the locus and the binding words are spoken. Any gold from the original pact will work. A single coin is sufficient — the Romans specified "gold, measured by weight" without a minimum quantity. A Keep vault will not work — the pact specifies "the earth." The earth at the locus. Nowhere else. *Sources: L5 (Roman ledger — the terms), L4 (Eadwine's chronicle — the binding words in Old English), L3 (Birmingham Museum — any coin from the hoard is valid).*